

# Develop Your First Firefox OS App

Firefox boasts of being open source and free of proprietary technology. Interestingly, the entire user interface is a Web app in itself, which can launch other apps. Currently, the Firefox OS requires new and interesting apps. This tutorial will guide you on how to develop your Firefox app.

**T**oday, we can find an application for almost any problem that we encounter. This is thanks to various developers and their creative ideas, which have resulted in the development of so many interesting applications.

Firefox app development is a good place to begin with for those with an interest in making an open source contribution or who would like to increase their knowledge on how mobile apps are developed. Moreover, if you have the ideas, you need to put them into action or else they get wasted. Firefox apps are just like Web pages, which can be viewed in your browser.

## Think of an interesting idea

The most important part of app development is the basic idea behind it. This could be anything—from solving a small issue in your locality to some giant project. The way we think decides the way we develop our app. We need to make good observations about things happening around us. Go out and understand the problems faced by people and then come out with a solution. Try to interact with mobile app users. Besides, use the mobile applications available and understand what is lacking in them—what additional feature you could add to them to improve their performance. You may think your idea is too simple, but it could be of help to many.

You can also go to the Firefox Marketplace, where all the Firefox products are available, to check the various apps before thinking of an idea.

## The coding skills you require

Once you are ready with some interesting idea, your next step is to implement it. An artist uses unique brushstrokes to give life to his imagination on canvas. For developers, this has to be done through various programming languages. So, you should have some knowledge of HTML, CSS and JavaScript, all of which will stand as the basic outline or skeleton of the application that you are going to develop. CSS will help you to beautify your app using interesting features. JavaScript will help you make the app dynamic by implementing interactions with the user. Ensure that you make the best use of all three, and make your app as user friendly and attractive as possible.

## Tools needed

Once you have the idea and the coding skills, you need to ensure that you have got all the tools ready to shape up your app and also to view it in a comfortable way. First, you need a good editor to write the code. You can think of using Sublime, Kate, Geany, Brackets, or even the basic text editor available with the OS.



Make sure that you have a Firefox browser running in your system; update it to the latest version to avoid any issues. You can view the app in the browser. If you want to work in the mobile domain (which is preferable), install the Firefox OS simulator; you will get it as a Firefox browser add-on.

You will have four types of files:

1. HTML
2. CSS
3. JavaScript
4. `webapp`

The first three types are related to the coding process with which we are familiar. The `webapp` file contains the basic details of the app you build. A more elaborate idea of `webapp` (especially regarding its contents) will be given in the upcoming section.

## Start building your app

I will demonstrate how to develop something very small like the 'Hello world' app. To begin with, create a directory named 'app' anywhere in your system. This will remain the directory of the 'Hello world' app we are going to build.

Now, to create the outline of the app, let's make use of